

Behind The Mask: A Shadowing Guide

For college and high school students pursuing medicine, nursing, dentistry, and similar health professions

Section I: Introduction and Purpose

What is medical shadowing and why does it matter?

- **Medical shadowing:** a clinical observation experience where a prospective or current healthcare student follows a licensed professional for several hours or days.
- Shadowing helps with learning more about a certain healthcare career, as you can witness what their daily routine looks like, and confirm passion for that profession.
- It can also help with learning medical terminology, gaining clinical experience, and having exposure to patient care.

How can shadowing fit into my pre-med/pre-health journey?

- Shadowing is a great way to help build a competitive **medical school application**. It is good to aim around over 100 hours of shadowing, total.
- It is also highly recommended to be shadowing **multiple professions** or **one profession** for a long amount of time.
- When writing about shadowing, you must write about what you learned from the profession. Although the amount of hours logged might be impressive, it is only meaningful to admission officers if you were able to take the knowledge with value.
- Specific and meaningful moments during shadowing can be used in a positive way when writing personal statements, or essays. They provide real, genuine examples and illustrate a passion for medicine.

Who is this guide for?

- This guide is for high school students who are exploring healthcare careers and what they are passionate about.
- It is also for undergrads who are looking to build clinical hours.

How will **Behind The Mask** support students at each step?

- Behind the Mask is an educational program built to reveal the path into medicine for high school students efficiently.
 - Most students interested in healthcare don't struggle because they lack ambition — they struggle because opportunities are difficult to obtain without a guide. This guide is designed to close that gap.
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Section II: Know What You're Looking for

Types of medical professionals to shadow

- Physicians (BS, MD, DO)
- Nurse practitioners
- Nurses
- Surgeons
- Specialists
- Residents

Clinical settings explained

- **Hospital inpatient clinics:** specialized units within a medical facility where patients are formally admitted by a physician for 24-hour care, requiring at least one overnight stay.
- **Hospital outpatient clinics:** medical facilities part of a hospital that provide diagnostics, treatment, and procedures without an overnight stay.
- **Urgent care:** walk-in medical facilities that provide prompt, non-emergency care for illnesses and injuries requesting attention within 24-48 hours.
- **Private practices:** a professional who works independently, owning their own business, rather than being employed by a hospital, government agency, or large corporation.
- **ERs:** standing for “emergency room”, a specialized hospital unit providing 24/7, immediate treatment for acute illnesses, severe trauma, and life-threatening conditions.
- **Surgical centers:** freestanding healthcare facilities that provide same-day surgical, diagnostic, and preventive procedures, allowing patients to return home within 24 hours.

Choosing a specialty that aligns with your interest

- **Below are some summaries of potential specialties you might take interest in:**
 - **Primary care:** a licensed medical professional that serves as the main, first point of contact for a patient’s health needs.
 - **Surgery:** a licensed health professional responsible for diagnosing, managing, and performing operative procedures on patients.
 - **Psychiatry:** a licensed medical professional specializing in diagnosing, treating, and preventing mental health disorders.
 - **Pediatrics:** a medical doctor who specializes in the comprehensive physical, emotional, and social health of infants, children, adolescents, and young adults, usually from birth up to age 21.
 - **OBGYN:** a physician specializing in female reproductive health, combining training in both obstetrics and gynecology.
- There are so many more careers that deserve recognition, these are just some of the most common.
- Always do extensive research on your preferred medical field you want to shadow before!

High school vs. college student considerations

- Note that most clinical facilities might reject high schoolers more often than college students.
- There are several guidelines that restrict this, such as age restrictions, supervision requirements, and what each level can realistically access.

- Medical shadowing helps provide clinical exposure to aspiring and current medical students, mainly at the college level. (The value of medical shadowing for high school students, NIH)
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Section III: Finding Opportunities

How to find physicians/professionals to shadow

- **Personal network**
 - Start with people that you already know. It is likely that somebody in your family knows a professional in the medical field; you can ask them to reach out, or do it yourself, and see the probability of being able to shadow.
 - Contacting your pediatrician, dentist, or optician is always an option, since they are medical professionals that you see frequently.
- **School contacts**
 - It is likely that your school counselor, or science teachers are in touch with a physician. It is always a good idea to ask them for a recommendation or information to shadow one since they are a close contact and your teachers know them personally. Always ask before doing cold outreach.
- **Cold outreach**
 - Cold call or cold email a local clinical setting close by your house, and ask the front desk if they allow shadowing. If they do, ask for a physician in a field that you are interested in that you could possibly shadow.
 - They will most likely connect you with them.
 - Many hospital systems have volunteering or shadowing programs set up – check their website or call their volunteer services department for any opportunities.
- **Formal programs**
 - Some organizations, hospitals, and medical schools run structured shadowing or pre-med programs. Make sure to do your research to ensure that you meet the requirements.

Virtual shadowing

- There are various alternatives to in-person opportunities. Many physicians and medical organizations now offer video-based observation experiences where you can observe consultations, case discussions, and medical education content through technology.
- It is not a perfect substitute for in-person clinical exposure, but it still demonstrates taking initiative, you can gain a lot of information from what you learn, and your knowledge can be useful when the time comes to receive an in-person opportunity.
- **Programs: American Academy of Family Physicians, Pre-Health Shadowing,** and various **university medical schools** offer virtual shadowing resources online.
 - When listing virtual shadowing on applications or resumes - list it as virtual to be transparent. It is important to be honest, and virtual shadowing is still recognized as meaningful exposure.

Dealing with rejection

- Rejection is extremely common. Many physicians receive many shadowing requests and have limited availability. If you are turned down:
 - Politely thank them and ask if they know anyone else who might be open to allowing shadowing from a student.
 - Try a different setting. If a private practice says no, try a hospital outpatient clinic, urgent care, or a different specialty.
 - Keep a log of who you have contacted so you don't accidentally reach out to the same person twice.
 - Give it time. It could take a long time, or you might even have to reach out in a new semester. But it could lead to a different outcome.
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Section IV: Reaching out & Getting Started

Crafting a professional email/letter of interest

- Your first impression matters. A well-written email can be the difference between getting a response or getting ignored. Keep it specific, professional, and personalized. Below is a template that you can use:

Subject: Shadowing Inquiry – [YOUR NAME], [HIGH SCHOOL / UNIVERSITY] Student

Dear Dr./Mr./Mrs./Miss [Last Name]

My name is [Your Name] and I am a [freshman/sophomore/junior/senior] at [School Name] with a strong interest in pursuing a career in medicine, specifically in [specialty if applicable]. I came across your name through [how you found them] and was truly impressed by [something SPECIFIC about their work or practice].

I am writing to respectfully ask whether you would be open to allowing me to shadow you for [X hours / a few sessions] at your convenience. I am eager to learn about the day-to-day responsibilities of a [physician/surgeon/specialist], and I am committed to being a respectful, unobtrusive presence in your clinical environment.

I am available [general availability, e.g. weekday mornings, weekends], but I am happy to work around your schedule entirely. I have attached my resume for your reference.

Thank you so much for your time and consideration. I would be honored by the opportunity.

Sincerely,

[Your Full Name]

[Phone Number] | [Email Address] | [School Name]

[ATTACH RESUME]

What to include in your outreach

- **Who you are:** Your name, school, and year.
- **Your goals:** Why you are interested in shadowing **them specifically** and what you hope to gain.
- **Your availability:** Be flexible and let them choose what works for them.
- **Why you chose them specifically:** A personal email stands out far more than a copy-and-pasted one.
- **A professional sign-off with your contact information and resume**

Following up appropriately

- If you don't hear back within one to two weeks, it is appropriate to send a brief, polite follow-up email.
- Keep it short – simply acknowledge that you sent a previous message and reiterate your interest. After two unanswered follow-ups, move on to your next contact.

What to prepare before your first day

- **Attire:** Dress in business casual or scrubs (make sure to ask your host what is appropriate). Avoid open-toed shoes, strong fragrances, and overly casual clothing.
- **HIPAA basics:** Understand that patient privacy is protected by law. Never photograph patients, discuss cases outside the clinical setting, or record anything without explicit permission.
- Prepare 3-5 thoughtful questions to ask your physician **during downtime/when appropriate**. This shows engagement and curiosity.
- Bring a small notebook to jot down observations, new vocabulary, and memorable moments. **Make sure to check with your host if using your phone for the same purposes is an option.**
- Arrive 10-15 minutes early on your first day.
 - ☐ **TIP:** Search up any medical terms or conditions relevant to your physician's speciality the night before. Walking in with basic knowledge shows initiative and helps you understand what you observe.

Section V: Making the Most of Your Experience

How to behave in a clinical setting

The way you conduct yourself during a shadowing experience speaks volumes. Remember that you are a guest in a professional environment where the priority is patient care.

- Stay out of the way. Position yourself where you can observe without being in the physician's path or too close to the patient.
- Never speak directly to patients unless you are introduced and explicitly invited to do so.
- Silence your phone. Keep it hidden from sight unless using it to take quick approved notes.
- Follow the physician's lead. If they step out, you step out. If they are focused, you observe quietly.
- Maintain a neutral, professional expression at all times, regardless of what you witness.

Questions to ask your physician

Downtime between patients is a great opportunity to engage. Here are some meaningful questions to consider:

- What drew you to this specialty, and would you choose it again?
 - What does a typical week look like outside of patient care (documentation, meetings, continuing education)?
 - What is the most challenging part of your role that people outside of medicine rarely see?
 - What advice would you give to someone at my stage who is serious about this path?
 - What qualities do you think make a great physician beyond clinical knowledge?
- ☐ **TIP:** Avoid asking questions that you could easily Google, like ‘How long is medical school?’ Show that you have done your homework and are asking because you want their personal experience.

How to take meaningful notes

You will not remember everything, but writing things down in the moment helps tremendously when you sit down to write about your experiences later.

- Note specific moments that surprised, moved, or challenged you.
- Record new vocabulary and look up definitions later.
- Write down direct quotes from your physician if something resonates with you.
- Log the date, setting, specialty, and approximate hours for each visit.
 - This can be on a spreadsheet.

Reflecting on your experience

After each shadowing session, take 10-15 minutes to write a short reflection. Ask yourself:

- What did I observe today that I did not expect?
- Did the experience reinforce or challenge my interest in this specialty?
- What did I learn about the physician-patient relationship?
- Was there a moment that will stay with me – and why?

These reflections can eventually become raw material to be able to use for your personal statement and secondary essays. Students who write the most compelling application essays are the ones who have been looking at small details all along.

Section VI: Logging & Documenting Hours

Why documentation matters

Medical school applications require you to list clinical experiences, and they will ask for the number of hours, setting, and contact information of your supervisor. If you cannot verify your hours, they may not count. Keeping a log from day one saves you enormous stress later.

How to track your hours accurately

Create a simple log (spreadsheets work well) with the following columns

- Date of the shadowing session
- Name and credentials of the physician (e.g. Dr. Jane Smith, MD)

- Specialty and clinical setting (e.g., pediatrics, outpatient clinic)
- Hours logged for that session
- Running total of hours
- Brief notes on what you observed

Getting a verification letter or signature

At the end of your shadowing experience – or periodically after a long engagement – ask your physician supervisor for a brief verification letter or signed confirmation of your hours. This letter should include:

- Their name, title, and contact information
- The dates of your shadowing and a total number of hours
- A brief statement confirming the nature of your experience

Keep digital and /or physical copies of this letter in a safe place. You may need it when you apply.

- ☐ **TIP:** Ask for verification while the relationship is still fresh – do not wait until a year later when the physician may not remember you clearly.

What applications ask for

Different application systems handle clinical experiences in slightly different ways, but most will ask you to:

- List the experience by name (e.g. Shadowing – Dr. Smith, MD, Internal Medicine)
- Enter the total number of hours
- Provide a contact name and email for verification
- Write a brief description of what you did and learned

AMCAS (used for MD programs) and AACOMAS (used for DO programs) both include a dedicated section for clinical experience. TMDSAS, used for Texas medical schools, has a similar format. Always remember to review the specific instructions for each application cycle, as formats can change.

Section VII: Turning Shadowing into Application Gold

How to write about shadowing in your personal statement

Admissions committees read thousands of personal statements. The ones that stand out do not simply list what the applicant observed – they reveal how those observations shaped their understanding of medicine and themselves.

A strong shadowing narrative typically follows this structure:

- Open with a specific, vivid moment.
- Describe what you observed and how you felt in the moment.
- Reflect on what that moment taught you – about medicine, patients, or yourself.
- Connect that lesson to your broader motivation for pursuing this career.

Identifying a meaningful moment vs. summarizing

The most common mistake students make is writing a summary rather than a story. Compare these two approaches:

- **Weak:** ‘During my shadowing, I observed surgeries and learned about the importance of teamwork in the OR’
- **Strong:** ‘As Dr. Smith sutured a patient’s wound in the ER, she paused and explained what she was doing – not to me, but to her patient. That moment of clear, deliberate communication in a stressful environment showed me that medicine is as much about presence as it is about skill.’

The second version is specific, shows genuine observation, and reveals something about the writer’s values and insight.

Using shadowing to assist your ‘why medicine’ narrative

Your personal statement should answer one core question: why do you want to be a physician?

Shadowing is your best evidence. Use it to demonstrate that your decision is grounded in firsthand exposure – not assumption, not TV, and not family expectations.

- ☐ **TIP:** Avoid writing about a single dramatic moment as though it alone confirmed your calling. Admissions readers are skeptical of this. Instead, show a pattern of observations across multiple experiences that reinforced and deepened your conviction.

Letters of recommendation from physicians you have shadowed

A letter of recommendation from a physician you shadowed can be a meaningful addition to your application – especially if that physician got to know you well over many sessions. A strong letter will speak to:

- Your curiosity and engagement during the experience
- Your professionalism and maturity in a clinical environment
- Any specific observations or conversations that revealed your character

To maximize the strength of a potential letter, invest in the relationship. Ask thoughtful questions, follow up after your shadowing with a thank-you note, and stay in touch.

Section VIII: FAQs & Common Mistakes

Frequently Asked Questions

I can’t find anyone to shadow – what do I do?

- Start smaller. Instead of targeting busy specialists at large hospitals, try urgent care clinics, family practices, or community health centers, which often have more flexibility. Consider reaching out to nursing homes, rehabilitation centers, or school nurses. Any clinical exposure is a step forward when you continue searching for physician shadowing.

How many hours is enough?

- For medical school applications, 100+ total hours of shadowing is a commonly cited benchmark, and more is generally better. However, quality matters more than quantity. 50 deeply reflective hours across medical specialties are more valuable than 200 passive ones in the same setting. Aim for breadth (at least two or three different specialties or settings) and depth.

Can I shadow someone I know personally?

- Yes, and this is actually one of the best ways to get started. Shadowing a family member, friend, neighbor, or your own physician is acceptable and widely done. The key is that the experience must be genuine – you should still be observing, reflecting, and learning.

Do all my hours need to be with physicians specifically?

- No. Shadowing nurses, nurse practitioners, physician-assistants, dentists, physical therapists, and other licensed professionals is valuable and counts as clinical exposure on most applications. However, if you are applying to MD or DO programs, you should also have dedicated physician (MD/DO) shadowing hours.

What if I realize I don't like the specialty I'm shadowing?

- This is a great outcome. Learning that a specialty is not for you is just as valuable as confirming that one is. Write about the experience honestly. Admissions committees respect self-awareness and the intellectual process of elimination.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

Being passive. Shadowing is not a spectator sport. Engage, observe carefully, and ask questions when appropriate.

Not reflecting. If you finish a shadowing experience without writing anything down or thinking about what you saw, you will struggle to write about it meaningfully later.

Shadowing only one specialty. Exposure to a single specialty gives a narrow picture of medicine. Try to shadow in at least two or three different environments.

Waiting until senior year. Start building shadowing hours as early as possible. This way, you have time, variety, and reflection before applications are due.

Forgetting to log hours. Memory fades. Log your hours after every session.

Treating it like a chore. If you see shadowing as something to 'get through', that attitude will show when you write your essays. Approach every session with genuine curiosity.

Section IX: Resources & Next Steps

Recommended reading and exploration

- The Student Doctor Network (SDN)
 - Forums and advice from pre-med students and medical professionals on shadowing, applications, and more
- AAMC's official pre-med resources
 - The Association of American Medical Colleges provides free guides on building a strong application
- NIH's National Library of Medicine
 - For reading about medical specialties and clinical research to prepare for your shadowing sessions
- Khan Academy MCAT prep
 - A free resource that also helps you understand the science behind what you will observe clinically

Virtual shadowing platforms

- MedSchoolCoach Virtual Shadowing
 - Offers structured virtual shadowing experiences across multiple specialties
- iHuman
 - Interactive patient case simulations used in medical education
- YouTube medical education channels
 - Osmosis, Ninja Nerd, and Medscape can supplement your learning between shadowing sessions

Your next steps

Here is a simple action plan to get started.

- Week 1: Identify 5-10 professionals in your network/local area to reach out to.
- Week 2: Send personalized emails using the template in this guide/your own.
- Week 3: Follow up on any unanswered emails. Research the specialty of anyone who responds.

Ongoing: Log every session, reflect after each visit, and keep your verification letters organized.

Long-term: Aim for variety across at least two or three specialties and a total of 100+ hours before applying.

You already have what it takes to get started. The path into medicine is long – but it begins with showing up, paying attention, and never stopping asking questions.